

TRIBAL ANTHROPOLOGY

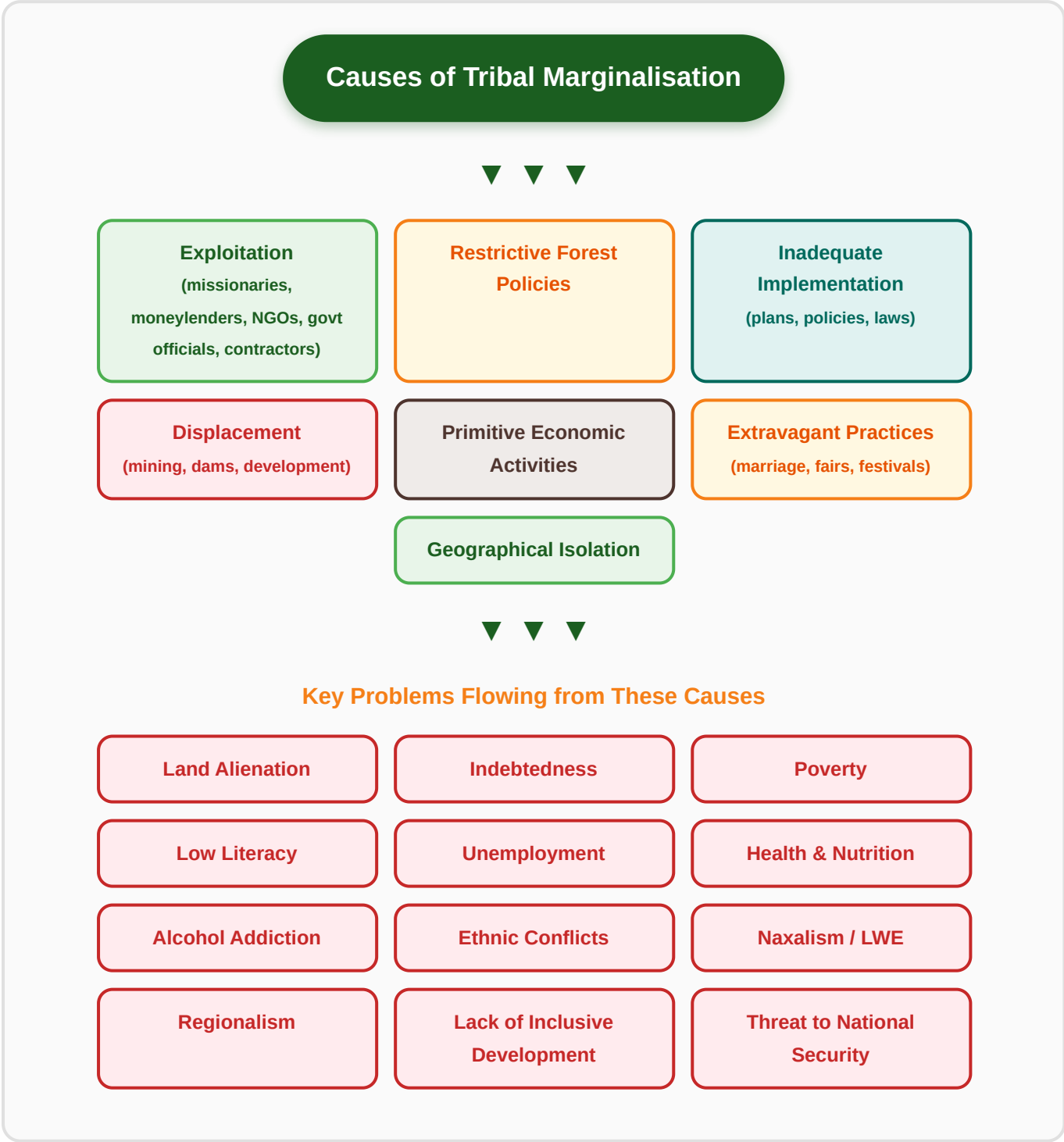
Part 2: Problems of Tribal Communities

Paper 2 — Unit 6.2 | Sarrthi IAS (Nataraj Sir)

UPSC CSE 2026 — Anthropology Optional

1. Land Alienation
 2. Poverty
 3. Indebtedness
 4. Tribal Education
 5. Unemployment & Underemployment
 6. Health & Nutrition
- + Master Scholar Table • Scheme Reference • 15 UPSC Questions

SOCIO-ECONOMIC MARGINALISATION FRAMEWORK



PROBLEM 1: LAND ALIENATION (6.2.1)

DEFINITION

Land alienation = the process by which tribals lose ownership or access to their traditional land.

 **Significance:** Land is not merely economic — it is the basis of **social identity**, **cultural continuity**, and **ecological survival**.

Key Scholar Views

  **L.P. Vidyarthi**

"Land alienation is the root cause of all forms of tribal unrest and discontent."

  **Dhebar Commission**

"The loss of land is the loss of livelihood, dignity, and identity."

  **Xaxa (2001)**

In Koraput (Odisha), tribal landholdings fell by over 50% between 1970–1990.

Nature of the Problem

Agriculture has historically been the primary occupation of tribal communities. Land alienation leads to **economic insecurity**, **cultural erosion**, and **social disintegration**. It forces tribals into wage labour or migration.

9 Major Causes of Land Alienation

Chronic Shortage of Cash

1

Low income forces borrowing at exploitative terms.

 **Example:** Korwa Tribe (MP) exploited by moneylenders who offer loans against land mortgage.

Inadequate Agricultural Yield

2

Traditional tools, lack of irrigation, small landholdings, infertile soils → subsistence-level productivity.

Chronic Indebtedness

3

Moneylenders exploit illiterate tribals, take land as mortgage.

💬 **Example:** Tharu and Bhoksa Tribes (UP) — post-Partition Punjab refugee moneylenders exploited locals through fraudulent contracts.

4

III Experience with State Credit Systems

Complex formalities and delays push tribals back to informal lenders.

5

Mining and Industrial Projects

- 261 Baiga families displaced by Vedanta's BALCO bauxite mining (Chhattisgarh)
- **Niyamgiri Hills (Odisha):** Dongria Kondhs resisted Vedanta's mining plans
- **Karanpura Coalfield** (Hazaribagh, Ramgarh, Ranchi, Latehar, Chatra): 83 coal blocks, 203 villages, 1,420 sq km, 425 sq km forest, 75,000+ ha acquired. Activist Mithilesh Dangi (Azadi Bachao Andolan) warns entire Barkagaon block will vanish

6

Infrastructure Projects (Dams)

- **Narmada Valley Project:** 12 Dec 1979 decision; 30 major + 135 medium + 3,000 small dams; 200,000 people displaced, majority Adivasis
- **Narmada Bachao Andolan** (1985 onwards): Mass protests

7

National Parks, Wildlife Sanctuaries, Tiger Reserves

- **Kanha Tiger Reserve (2014):** ~450 Baiga and Gond families evicted
- **Kuno National Park:** Asmita Kabra (2009) — 80% displaced Saharias below poverty line
- **Assam (2017):** 1,000 Bodo, Rabha, Mishing people evicted from Orang NP
- 🟢 **Positive Example — Soliga tribes** (Biligirirangana Hills): Allowed to stay — tiger population INCREASED (co-existence works!)

8

Forest Policies

Indian Forest Act 1927 — removed community ownership, criminalised traditional livelihoods.

9

Lack of Implementation of Laws

LARR Act 2013 — poor implementation across states.

Other Modes of Land Alienation

- **Court machinery:** Moneylenders drag defaulting tribals to court; legal ignorance ensures loss
- **Temptation of immediate gains:** Tribals lured into selling for short-term cash
- **Voluntary surrender:** Engineered by landlords exploiting tribal illiteracy

Typologies of Land Alienation

Type	Mechanism
Through private transactions	Mortgaging, sale, illegal sale, encroachments
Through survey & settlements	Cultivation land categorised as govt land; shifting cultivation as state-owned
Notification of forests	Encroachments eligible but not regularised; shifting cultivation areas categorised as forests
Land acquisition & displacement	Compulsory acquisition for projects
Poor distribution of govt wastelands	Government wastelands not distributed equitably

⚠️ 5 Consequences of Land Alienation

⚠️ Consequences

1. **Loss of livelihood** — dispossession from forest and cultivable land
2. **Erosion of traditional institutions** — Khuntkatti (Mundas) and Bhuinhari (Oraons) collapse
3. **Migration and urban drift** — seasonal migration to Raipur, Ranchi, brick kilns
4. **Social stratification** — **B.K. Roy Burman**: class differentiation within the tribe
5. **Conflict and unrest** — **Walter Fernandes**: displacement links to development-induced impoverishment

👩 Impact on Tribal Women

- Lose access to forest produce, firewood, fodder, shifting cultivation plots
- **Baiga and Gond (MP)**: women who managed Bewar fields now depend on daily wages
- Displacement negotiations only with male heads — women left without ownership or compensation
- **Polavaram Dam (AP)**: female-headed households least compensated, most food insecure

📜 Protective Legislations

Legislation	Purpose
Chotanagpur Tenancy Act (1908)	Restricts tribal land transfer to non-tribals in Jharkhand
Santhal Pargana Tenancy Act (1949)	Prohibits land transfer even for public purposes
FRA 2006	Recognises individual and community rights to land/forest
LARR Act 2013	Fair compensation and rehabilitation

📌 Scheduled Areas & Scheduled Tribes Commission (1961) Recommendations:

- Detailed scrutiny of land laws
- General prohibition on all land transfers from tribals to non-tribals without DC permission

💡 Way Forward

- Effective enforcement of existing land protection laws
- Participatory governance with tribal consent
- Community land rights under FRA

- Tribal consent + compensation + cultural continuity in all projects



PROBLEM 2: POVERTY (6.2.2)

OVERVIEW

Multi-dimensional and structural problem rooted in **historical marginalisation, resource deprivation, and exclusion from development.**



Key Statistics

62.3%

STs below poverty line
(Rural, 2004-05)

45.3%

STs below poverty line
(Rural, 2011-12)

35.5%

STs below poverty (Urban,
2004-05)

24.1%

STs below poverty (Urban,
2011-12)

📌 Declined but still the **POOREST** social group in India.



D.N. Majumdar

"Tribal poverty is not merely economic but an outcome of dislocation from the ecological niche and exploitation by the dominant society."

Historical Context

Colonial forest and land policies, post-Independence industrialisation, state-led development displaced tribal communities. India's growth (industrial expansion, Green Revolution, urbanisation) bypassed the subsistence tribal economy.

B.D. Sharma's 5 Levels of Deprivation

1

Non-recognition of Rights over Resources

Denied access to forest, land, water. **Example:** Loss of ancestral land during Narmada Dam without prior informed consent.

2

Alienation of Workers from Means of Production

Pushed into bonded/daily wage labour. **Example:** Bonded labour in central India.

3

Denial of Due Instalment of Labour

Unfair wages below minimum. **Example:** Adivasi tea workers in Assam earn less than non-tribals for same work.

4

Bartering of Liberty

Trafficking and forced prostitution. **Example:** Tribal women/girls in Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh.

5

Psychological State of Accepting Deprivation

Loss of self-respect, fatalism, internalised poverty from continuous exploitation.

Additional Causes of Tribal Poverty

Cause	Details
Moneylenders & Debt	Dependence on private moneylenders; land mortgaged and lost
Developmental Displacement	Dams, mining displace lakhs of tribals
Systemic Barriers to Mobility	Discrimination, remoteness, lack of political voice; exclusion from skill programmes
Lack of Education & Healthcare	NFHS-5: high malnutrition and infant mortality; education gaps restrict employment
Weak Welfare Implementation	IRDP, NREP, MGNREGA, PDS, Tribal Sub-Plan fail to reach remote tribal regions



Case Studies



Tharu and Bhoksa (Uttar Pradesh)

Exploited by post-Partition Punjab refugee moneylenders through fraudulent contracts and predatory lending.



Baiga and Gond (Madhya Pradesh)

Kanha Tiger Reserve evictions (2014) deepened poverty — ~450 families lost forest-based livelihoods.



Saharias (Madhya Pradesh)

Asmita Kabra (2009) — post-displacement poverty due to loss of Minor Forest Produce (MFP) access after Kuno National Park relocation. 80% fell below poverty line.

5 Consequences of Poverty

Consequences

1. **Chronic indebtedness** — moneylenders exploit through unfair interest; Santhals mortgage land
2. **Dehumanising conditions** — NFHS-5: 54% lack improved sanitation; 47% lack safe drinking water
3. **Health deterioration** — infant mortality 40% higher than national average (MoTA, 2021); malaria, diarrhoea, TB
4. **Loss of autonomy** — dependence on MGNREGA/PDS weakens traditional systems
5. **Inter-generational deprivation** — **L.P. Vidyarthi** noted vicious cycle in Ranchi tribal studies

Impact on Tribal Women

- Multiple subsistence tasks (firewood, water, wage labour) without recognition
- **Santhal women:** average daily work exceeds 12 hours (ICSSR study)
- Women eat last and least — over 60% anaemia among tribal females (NFHS-5)



Government Schemes for Tribal Poverty

Scheme	Key Feature
IRDP	Assisted 42% tribal families up to 8th Plan
Tribal Sub-Plan (1974-75)	Plan funds proportional to tribal population
FRA 2006	Restores individual/community forest rights
PESA Act 1996	Self-governance through Gram Sabhas
LARR Act 2013	Fair compensation and rehabilitation
PM-JANMAN (2024)	Focuses on PVTGs — saturation of basic services
EMRS	Quality education in tribal areas
Van Dhan Yojana	Value addition of forest produce

 **B.D. Sharma**

"The tribal world is being impoverished in the name of development." Real change requires inclusive, rights-based, culturally sensitive governance.



Way Forward

1. Strengthen implementation of FRA, PESA, land-tenancy laws
2. Promote education in tribal languages and contextual curricula
3. Develop community-based forest management and eco-tourism
4. Expand livelihood diversification through skill development
5. Ensure participatory planning and respect for tribal consent

PROBLEM 3: INDEBTEDNESS (6.2.3)

OVERVIEW

One of the **oldest and most persistent** problems. Traditional tribal societies were based on subsistence and reciprocity. Contact with the money economy introduced cash dependency, credit, and exploitation.

 **Christoph von Fürer-Haimendorf**

"The shift from barter to monetised economy exposed tribals to exploitation by moneylenders, contractors, traders."

 **Rangarajan**

About 36% of ST farmer households are indebted, mostly to non-institutional sources.

 **Extent:** Widespread across India, except in a few NE areas historically protected from middlemen during colonial times.

5 Causes of Indebtedness

1 Loss of Rights over Forests

Forest restrictions (Indian Forest Act 1927) displaced tribals from livelihoods.

 **Tripathi:** Tribes once shared a harmonious and symbiotic relationship with forests.

2 Poor Cultivation Methods

Primitive tools, low productivity, no irrigation → no surplus to save.

3 Ignorance and Market Exploitation

Illiteracy and unfamiliarity with commerce makes tribals prey to merchants and moneylenders.

4 Extravagant Ceremonial Spending

Social prestige requires lavish marriage/festival celebrations. Borrowing at high interest becomes inevitable.

5 Role of Moneylenders

Formal credit fails (bureaucratic hurdles). Moneylender offers immediate cash without documents but at exorbitant interest rates.

! 5 Consequences of Indebtedness

! Consequences

1. **Loss of Freedom** — borrower and family become bonded labourers.



Sahariya Tribe (Baran, Rajasthan)

Works under Hali system despite Bonded Labour Abolition Act 1976.

2. **Alienation of Land** — land seized by creditors → chronic landlessness
3. **Sale of Girls / Human Trafficking** — debt repayment leads to sale of daughters.



Bedia Community

Women pushed into prostitution as debt-repayment mechanism.

4. **Health Impacts** —  **V.G. Rao** (Jabalpur, MP): 36.5% prevalence of STDs among tribal villagers
5. **Bonded Labour / Hereditary Debt** — permanent servitude across generations.



Juang PVTGs (Odisha)

Goti system binds families for GENERATIONS despite Orissa Debt Bondage Abolition Act 1948.  **Anumeha Yadav**: practice continues despite laws.

Impact on Tribal Women

- Pushed into bonded labour or sexual exploitation
- **Ho and Munda women** (Jharkhand/Odisha): employed as domestic servants through exploitative networks
- Indebtedness breaks kinship support → vulnerable to trafficking and migration-related abuse

Legislations against Indebtedness

Legislation	Purpose
AP Scheduled Areas Moneylenders Regulation 1963	Regulates credit in tribal areas
Mysore Pawnbrokers Act 1961	Controls lending practices and interest rates
Assam Money Lending Regulation 1968	Restricts exploitative lending
Fifth Schedule of Constitution	Empowers states to regulate moneylending in Scheduled Areas
MP (2019): Anusuchit Jan Jaati Sahukar Viniyam 1972	All loans from unlicensed moneylenders waived
NSTFDC	PSU under MoTA; concessional loans for income generation
AMSY	Loans up to 90% for projects up to ₹2 lakh at 4% p.a. for tribal women
MCF for SHGs	Up to ₹50,000 per member; max ₹5 lakh per SHG

 **Analysis:** Despite laws, implementation remains weak. Indebtedness is both cause and consequence of underdevelopment. **Need:** secure land rights, community banking, financial literacy.

PROBLEM 4: TRIBAL EDUCATION (6.2.4)

59%

ST Literacy (Census 2011)

73%

National Literacy (2011)

14 pts

Gap from National Average

 Verrier Elwin

"Education must be OF THE FOREST and not AGAINST the forest."

 Education Statistics

Indicator	Value
ST Literacy (2001)	47.1%
ST Literacy (2011)	59%
ST Male Literacy	68.5%
ST Female Literacy	Below 50%
Highest ST Literacy	Mizoram (91.6%)
Lowest ST Literacy	Andhra Pradesh (49.2%)
Gap from National Average	~14 points

 States with gaps exceeding 18 points: **Tamil Nadu, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal, Kerala**



Constitutional Provisions

Article	Provision
Article 46	Promote educational/economic interests of SCs, STs, weaker sections
Article 29(1)	Right to conserve language, script, culture
Article 15(4)	Special provisions for educational advancement
Article 275(1)	Grants-in-aid for tribal welfare including education
Article 350A	Mother tongue instruction at primary stage for linguistic minorities

6 Causes of Educational Backwardness

1

Poor Socio-Economic Conditions

Education seen as luxury; children engaged in wage labour. Girl child suffers most.

2

Lack of Infrastructure

Few schools, far distances, no electricity/sanitation/teachers in remote areas.

3

Language Barrier

Schools teach in regional/national language, NOT mother tongue → high dropouts. Article 350A seldom implemented.

4

Teacher Challenges

Few trained/willing teachers for remote areas; cultural insensitivity and absenteeism.

5

Gender Disparity

ST female literacy lags by ~20%. Early marriage, no girls' hostels, poor hygiene → dropouts.

6

Low Parental Motivation & Cultural Disconnect

Schools alienate children from traditional occupations and values.

⚠️ 5 Consequences

⚠️ Consequences

1. **Low literacy and dropouts** — linguistic gaps + poor infrastructure
2. **Limited employability** — lack of English/technical skills; most in low-paid jobs despite reservation
3. **Cultural alienation** — Gonds in MP find Hindi-medium education difficult
4. **Gender disparity** — Female 49% vs Male 68%. 👤 **Xaxa Committee (2014)**: early marriage + household chores reduce girls' schooling
5. **Leadership deficit** — 👤 **S.C. Dube (1955)**: educated intermediaries form tribal elite sometimes serving self-interest

👤 Impact on Tribal Women

- ST male literacy 68.5%, ST female literacy less than 50%
- Girls drop out due to: distance, safety concerns, early marriage
- **Example**: AP's PVTGs (Chenchu, Konda Reddi) — girls leave after Class V due to lack of female teachers and hostels

📜 Education Schemes

Scheme	Purpose
EMRS	Quality residential schools for STs (like Navodaya)
Ashram Schools	Residential schools in remote tribal areas
Pre/Post-Matric Scholarships	Financial aid for ST students
TSP & Article 275(1) Grants	Funding for educational infrastructure
NEP 2020	Bilingual education; local knowledge systems
Adivasi Mahila Shikshan Kendra	Literacy centres for tribal women



6 Suggestions / Way Forward



Way Forward

1. **Infrastructure:** Expand EMRS; recruit local teachers; bilingual systems (TSR Subramanian Committee + NEP 2020); Kerala's "One Family, One Job" model
2. **Teacher Training:** Cultural awareness programmes; Tribal History and Culture Exhibitions
3. **Student Safety:** Protect from abuse (Muzaffarpur case; Maharashtra 29 tribal girls exploited 2011-16)
4. **Girls' Education:** Build girls' schools/hostels in remote areas; bicycles (Bihar model); menstrual hygiene scheme
5. **Awareness & Community Mobilisation:** Camps, street dramas, puppet shows
6. **Regular Monitoring:** Periodic reviews by District Collectors/Tribal Welfare Officers



Verrier Elwin

"Let us teach the tribe not to despise his culture, but to enrich it through knowledge."

PROBLEM 5: UNEMPLOYMENT & UNDEREMPLOYMENT (6.2.5)

OVERVIEW

Nearly **75% of tribals** are in agriculture (mostly subsistence). Structural issues arise from loss of livelihood, lack of education, displacement, and marginalisation.

 **Richard Mahapatra**

"Tribals are quitting farming fast, and every second household now survives on manual labour in an informal economy."

Occupational Profile

Sector	Details
Agriculture & allied	75% of tribals
Pastoral & herding	Todas (Nilgiris), Bhotias, Gaddis, Bakarwals
Artisans & blacksmiths	Asur and Agaria
Foragers	Chenchu, Paniya, Onge
Industrial & migrant	Construction, domestic, mining



NSSO 2011-12 Statistics

Category	Rate	Change
Urban ST Unemployment — Male	3.4%	Up from 2.9%
Urban ST Unemployment — Female	4.8%	Up from 3.4%
Rural ST Unemployment — Male	1.3%	Up from 1.1%
Rural ST Unemployment — Female	1.1%	Up from 0.4%
Rural Self-employed	56.4%	Mainly agriculture
Rural Casual Labour	38.8%	—
Rural Regular/Salaried	4.8%	—

8 Causes of Unemployment

1

Loss of Traditional Livelihood

Forest laws + industrial expansion. Tribal Health Report notes sharp decline in forest-based livelihoods.

2

Displacement and Migration

Development projects force migration as contract labourers/domestic workers.

3

Educational Deprivation

Lack of quality schooling/vocational training; most lack modern skills or career counselling.

4

Infrastructural Deficit

Poor roads, electricity, internet in tribal regions.

5

Discrimination and Marginalisation

Stereotypes → wage discrimination, fewer opportunities.

6

Agricultural Dependence and Seasonality

Over-reliance on rain-fed agriculture → seasonal unemployment.

7

Vacant Reserved Posts

112th Parliamentary Standing Committee (2023): 1,199 of 3,097 ST-reserved posts in 45 central universities + over 3,000 in ministries remain VACANT.

 **Saiyed Zegham Murtaza:** "These figures betray extreme disregard of reservation norms."

8

Frustration and Extremism

Lack of opportunity → some youth join extremist movements.

5 Consequences

Consequences

1. **Seasonal underemployment** —  **N.C. Saxena:** agriculture/forest work limited to 4-5 months/year
2. **Distress migration** — Jharkhand/Odisha to brick kilns in AP, factories in Surat/Mumbai — without social security
3. **Skill mismatch** — National Skill Dev Report (2018): less than 2% of tribal youth formally trained
4. **Rise in bonded labour** — persistent poverty/debt in MP and Rajasthan (ILO, 2016)
5. **Psychological stress** —  **Bhatia:** Bastar studies link unemployment with Naxal recruitment

Impact on Tribal Women

- Dominate manual labour, construction, forest collection — little job security
- **Bastar:** over 70% of employed tribal women = seasonal agricultural labourers under MGNREGA, earning less than men
- Decline in forest/agriculture jobs forces migration as domestic workers, brick kiln labourers
- **Ranchi and Sundargarh:** rising female migration to Delhi/Mumbai → loss of community support



Government Measures

Measure	Details
NREP, RLEGP → JRY → MGNREGA	ST participation peaked at 36% first year, dropped to 16% (2013-14), stabilised 17-20%. Tribals = 20% of MGNREGA workers (twice population share) — AARM 2023
NSTFDC	Concessional loans; promotes entrepreneurship
VTCs (Vocational Training Centres)	Skills in handicrafts, tailoring, carpentry
Scheme for Management of Career Aspirations of ST Students (2018-19)	Counselling, scholarships, placement
EMRS	Quality education and employability skills
India's First Tribal Employment Exchange (Trivandrum, 2018)	Links tribal youth with jobs



Way Forward

1. **Tribal Skill Development Centres** — local crafts, agro-processing, tourism, renewable energy
2. **Forest-based industries** — bamboo, honey, herbal cooperatives; Public-Tribal Partnerships
3. **Strengthen MGNREGA** — prioritise tribal regions; timely payments; social audits
4. **Fill ST reserved posts backlog** — regular audits
5. **Support tribal start-ups** under Start-Up India with NSTFDC funding
6. **Workplace diversity campaigns** — enforce equal pay



B.D. Sharma

"Tribals are not poor by culture, but made poor by circumstance. True empowerment lies in creating dignified and skill-based employment that values both economic and cultural capital."

PROBLEM 6: HEALTH & NUTRITION (6.2.6)

OVERVIEW

STs = **8.6% of population** (Census 2011) but health indicators **10-25% lower** than non-tribals.

 **Abhay Bang Committee (2018)**

"Tribal India faces a TRIPLE BURDEN of communicable diseases, NCDs, and mental health problems."



Key Health Statistics

Indicator	Tribal	National	Source
Life Expectancy	63.9 years	67 years	Lancet
IMR (2019-21)	41.6%	—	SRS/NFHS
Under-5 Stunting	44%	38%	NFHS-4
Underweight Children	45%	36%	NFHS-4
Wasting	27%	21%	NFHS-4
Adolescent Girls BMI < 18.5	~50%	—	NFHS-4

Disease Burden

30% All malaria cases	60% P. falciparum cases	50% Malaria deaths (Bang 2018)	703 TB per 100K (vs 256 national, ICMR 2021)
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 **NCDs:** 66% of tribal deaths are from NCDs (ICMR) — cardiovascular, diabetes, cancer, chronic respiratory diseases.

Triple Burden of Disease

Communicable	Non-Communicable	Mental Health

- Malaria
- TB
- Leprosy
- Diarrhoea
- Respiratory infections

- Diabetes
- Hypertension
- Cancer
- Chronic respiratory

- Displacement stress
- Cultural erosion
- Alcoholism
- Rising suicide

6 Major Causes

1

Lack of Awareness / Mistrust

Illness attributed to supernatural causes; reliance on ojhas, baigas, deotas. Low vaccine acceptance.

2

Unhygienic Practices

Inadequate soap/clean water/sanitation → high maternal/infant mortality. Open defecation, unclean childbirth.

3

Poor Health Infrastructure

27-40% shortfall in PHCs/Sub-centres/CHCs; 33% shortage of PHC doctors. Tripura review (2022): poor access, power, equipment.

4

Financial Constraints

TSP allocations diverted or underutilised.

5

Lack of Micro-Level Data

Health planning ignores tribe-specific issues (sickle-cell anaemia, goitre in Himalayan tribes).

6

Malnutrition / Food Insecurity

Poverty + loss of forest food → protein/micronutrient deficiency. AARM warns food subsidy cuts could intensify hunger.

5 Consequences

Consequences

1. **High mortality** — life expectancy 5-6 years lower; malaria, sickle cell anaemia, fluorosis common (ICMR 2022)
2. **Child malnutrition** — NFHS-5: 45% under-5 stunted, 27% wasted; worst in MP, CG, Jharkhand
3. **Maternal health risk** — 59% ST women anaemic; low institutional deliveries due to distance/mistrust
4. **Reduced productivity** — malnourishment weakens physical strength
5. **Decline of traditional medicine** — indigenous healers sidelined.  **P.C. Joshi:** integration of ethnomedicine with PHCs could improve outcomes



MAJOR CASE STUDY: Keonjhar District, Odisha



The Paradox of Prosperity Without Well-Being

- One of India's **richest mineral belts** — 26% of country's iron ore reserves
- Revenue through DMF and OMBADC exceeding **₹15,000 crore**
- **DESPITE** financial wealth: **worst-performing** in child and maternal health
- NFHS-5: **74.7%** pregnant women anaemic (state average 61.8%); 25.9% women low BMI
- Highest stunted, wasted, underweight children in Odisha
- Remote village **Emiri** inaccessible by ambulance — women travel 20+ km for delivery



Significance: Extractive wealth ≠ tribal well-being. Mineral revenue does not translate to health outcomes.



Impact on Tribal Women

- **Maternal mortality:** 167 per lakh live births (higher than national average, NFHS-5)
- **Dahanu (Maharashtra):** 1 in 3 pregnancies anaemic or underweight
- Cultural barriers keep women from antenatal care/contraception
- **Santhal and Bhil women:** home births by untrained midwives → infection, complications



CASE STUDY: Gadchiroli Model (Maharashtra)



Dr. Abhay and Rani Bang's SEARCH Initiative

- Successfully reduced **neonatal mortality** by training village health workers
- Home-based newborn care model
- Shows power of **community participation**, local training, traditional integration

Government Initiatives

Policy Frameworks

Initiative	Details
NHM (tribal sub-plans, ASHA workers)	Primary healthcare infrastructure and outreach
Abhay Bang Committee (2018)	Comprehensive roadmap for tribal health
SWASTHYA Portal	Digital health tracking for tribal areas
E-newsletter ALEKH	Health awareness and knowledge dissemination

Disease-Specific

Programme	Details
Aashwasan Campaign (2022)	TB awareness in 177 tribal districts, 10 million people
Malaria Elimination Programme (2030)	Target: malaria-free India by 2030

Nutrition

Scheme	Details
ICDS	Supplementary nutrition for mothers and children
Poshan Abhiyaan	Reduce stunting/underweight/anaemia
Mid-Day Meal Scheme	Nutrition in schools

Infrastructure

Measure	Details
Tribal Health Centres	Dedicated centres in tribal blocks
Mobile Medical Units	Reaching remote habitations
ASHAs and ANMs from tribal communities	Culturally sensitive health workers



5 Suggestions / Way Forward



Way Forward

1. **Integrate Traditional + Modern Medicine** — AYUSH + Allopathy; recognise healers (baigas, ojhas) as intermediaries
2. **Health Literacy** — folk media, street plays, storytelling in tribal languages; school-based health education
3. **Infrastructure** — fill doctor vacancies; incentivise service; hostels for expectant mothers; improve ambulance access
4. **Strengthen Nutrition** — locally grown food through PDS; restore forest rights for traditional food access
5. **Policy** — ensure direct TSP fund utilisation; create National Tribal Health Mission (NTHM) with state monitoring



Bang Committee (2019)

"Tribal health is a test of India's commitment to equity."

MASTER SCHOLAR TABLE — ALL TOPICS

#	Scholar / Body	Key Contribution
1	Marshall Sahlins	Hunter-gatherers as the "Original Affluent Society"
2	Verrier Elwin	"Education must be OF the forest, not AGAINST the forest"; tribal isolationist approach
3	L.P. Vidyarthi	"Land alienation is the root cause of all forms of tribal unrest"; inter-generational poverty cycle (Ranchi studies)
4	B.D. Sharma	5 Levels of Deprivation; "Tribal world impoverished in the name of development"
5	D.N. Majumdar	Tribal poverty as dislocation from ecological niche + exploitation by dominant society
6	Dhebar Commission	"Loss of land is the loss of livelihood, dignity, and identity"
7	N.K. Bose	Hindu method of tribal absorption; tribe-caste continuum
8	B.K. Roy Burman	Class differentiation within tribes due to land alienation
9	Walter Fernandes	Displacement linked to development-induced impoverishment
10	S.C. Dube (1955)	Educated tribal intermediaries forming elite serving self-interest; leadership deficit
11	Xaxa Committee (2014)	Tribal landholdings decline; early marriage + chores reduce girls' schooling; comprehensive tribal welfare recommendations
12	Christoph von Fürer-Haimendorf	Shift from barter to monetised economy exposed tribals to exploitation
13	Ranganathan	36% of ST farmer households indebted, mostly to non-institutional sources
14	Tripathi	Tribes once shared harmonious and symbiotic relationship with forests
15	V.G. Rao	36.5% prevalence of STDs among tribal villagers (Jabalpur, MP)
16	Anumeha Yadav	Documented continuation of Goti system (bonded labour) in Juang PVTGs despite laws
17	Richard Mahapatra	"Tribals quitting farming fast; every second household survives on manual labour"

#	Scholar / Body	Key Contribution
18	N.C. Saxena	Agriculture/forest work limited to 4-5 months/year → seasonal underemployment
19	Bhatia	Bastar studies linking unemployment with Naxal recruitment
20	Saiyed Zegham Murtaza	"Figures betray extreme disregard of reservation norms" — vacant ST posts
21	Abhay Bang Committee (2018/2019)	Triple burden of disease; "Tribal health is a test of India's commitment to equity"; Gadchiroli model
22	P.C. Joshi	Integration of ethnomedicine with PHCs could improve outcomes
23	Asmita Kabra (2009)	80% displaced Saharias below poverty line after Kuno NP relocation
24	Marija Gimbutas	Kurgan hypothesis — Proto-Indo-European homeland and migration theory
25	Robert Caldwell	Pioneer of Dravidian linguistic family classification
26	Krishnamurti	Dravidian language family studies; linguistic classification of tribes
27	Morris Swadesh	Glottochronology — method for estimating language divergence time
28	Abbi	Documentation of Great Andamanese language and endangered tribal languages
29	Anderson	Linguistic documentation of endangered Munda and tribal languages
30	Colin Masica	South Asian linguistic area; defining features of Indian language convergence

MASTER GOVERNMENT SCHEMES — QUICK

REFERENCE

Scheme / Act	Year	Purpose
Chotanagpur Tenancy Act	1908	Restricts tribal land transfer to non-tribals in Jharkhand
Indian Forest Act	1927	State control over forests; criminalised tribal forest use
Santhal Pargana Tenancy Act	1949	Prohibits land transfer even for public purposes
ICDS	1975	Supplementary nutrition for mothers and children
Tribal Sub-Plan	1974-75	Plan funds proportional to tribal population share
Bonded Labour Abolition Act	1976	Abolishes bonded labour system
TRIFED	1987	Marketing of tribal products; Van Dhan centres
PESA Act	1996	Self-governance through Gram Sabhas in Scheduled Areas
MGNREGA	2005	100 days guaranteed employment; tribals = 20% of beneficiaries
NHM	2005	Primary healthcare infrastructure; ASHA workers
FRA (Forest Rights Act)	2006	Recognises individual and community forest rights
MLE Programme	2006	Multilingual education in mother tongue at primary level
LARR Act	2013	Fair compensation and rehabilitation for land acquisition
Poshan Abhiyaan	2018	Reduce stunting, underweight, anaemia
NEP 2020	2020	Bilingual education; local knowledge systems integration
Aashwasan Campaign	2022	TB awareness in 177 tribal districts
PM-JANMAN	2024	Saturation of basic services for PVTGs
Van Dhan Yojana	—	Value addition and marketing of forest produce
EMRS	—	Quality residential schools for STs (like Navodaya)
NSTFDC	—	PSU under MoTA; concessional loans for income generation
AMSY	—	Loans up to 90% for projects up to ₹2 lakh at 4% p.a. for tribal women

Scheme / Act	Year	Purpose
SPPEL	—	Scheme for Protection, Preservation of Endangered Languages
SWASTHYA Portal	—	Digital health tracking for tribal areas
Malaria Elimination Programme	2030 target	Malaria-free India



15 PROBABLE UPSC QUESTIONS

Q1

20 marks

Describe the economic life of Indian tribes with special reference to hunting and gathering, pastoralism, and shifting cultivation. Give ethnographic examples.

Q2

20 marks

What is the Nilgiri inter-tribal interdependence model? Discuss its anthropological significance and the impact of modernisation on it.

Q3

15 marks

Critically examine the Apatani rice-fish farming system as a model of indigenous sustainable agriculture.

Q4

15 marks

Discuss the linguistic classification of tribes in India with examples from each major language family.

Q5

10 marks

What are endangered tribal languages? What measures have been taken for their protection and preservation?

Q6

20 marks

"Land alienation is the root cause of all forms of tribal unrest and discontent." — L.P. Vidyarthi. Discuss with reference to causes, consequences, and remedial measures.

Q7

15 marks

Critically examine the problem of tribal indebtedness in India with reference to its causes, consequences, and legislative interventions.

Q8

15 marks

Discuss the educational problems of tribal communities in India. How can bilingual education and culturally sensitive curricula help?

Q9**15 marks**

Analyse the problem of unemployment and underemployment among tribal communities in India. Suggest a way forward.

Q10**20 marks**

"Tribal health is a test of India's commitment to equity." — Abhay Bang Committee. Critically examine the health and nutrition issues of tribal communities in India.

Q11**10 marks**

What do you understand by the Keonjhar paradox? What does it reveal about tribal health and resource extraction dynamics in India?

Q12**15 marks**

Discuss the impact of land alienation, poverty, and indebtedness on tribal women in India with case studies.

Q13**10 marks**

Write a note on the significance of the Forest Rights Act, 2006 in addressing the problems of tribal communities.

Q14**15 marks**

"Traditional shifting cultivation is not primitive but a sophisticated system of sustainable agroecology." Evaluate with reference to Maler and Baiga tribes.

Q15**15 marks**

Compare and contrast the hunting-gathering economies of Chenchu, Onge, and Jarawa tribes, highlighting their ecological adaptations.